



PRODUCTION SOUND BASICS

The location..visit it 2x AM/PM

- Listen for traffic, planes, hvac, acoustics
- Can hvac and other noise emitting objects be controlled?
- If noisy and no control, can location be moved?
- If using generator (blimping- noise reduction varies), make sure the generator is placed far away. Insist on a long cable run if necessary.

Fundamentals

- Mono or stereo?
- Multiple Mics? Mixers?
- Who is doing post and where?
- What is the post setup?
- Sound crew should be at least 2 (mixer and boom op or "performer" of the actions being recorded).



It usually works this way...

- Atmosphere and crowd tracks are rec in stereo
- Passbys (car/train) are rec in mono. Stereo/surround mix done in post.
- Car interior fx in mono.
- Spot sfx (doors, phones, toilet) in mono.
- Dialogue in MONO

Noise issues

- Even if set is impossibly noisy (for instances of recording motion capture), still record dialogue. Guide track will be needed for ADR.
- There will always be ambience. It is a good thing to a certain level.
- Sound mixer's job: best **signal to noise ratio** possible.

Sound crew #3...ideal

- Performs maintenance on equipment.
- Second boom/performer when required.
- Cable handling for any recording that requires movement
- Setting up equipment, packing and shifting.
- Filling out log sheets.
- Maintaining batteries, tape, and external drives.

Equipment testing on delivery

- Setup equipment – make sure you have everything you need including spares (batteries, xlr, mixer and other cables, mics, accessories).
- Run tests – make sure everything is in working order, connects, turns on.
- Record, and evaluate.

The big day Part 1

- What time is the first shoot?
- Unpack equipment near the shooting area.
- Test again.
- Record reference tone.
- Record verbal ID of production and tape number.
- Set timecode to reference in logs.

The big day part 2

- Playback recording and listen for quality of recording
- Check mic suspension and pole for noise.
- Make out a sound log (takes, timecodes, locations).
- Sound report sheet for each take (good takes, time code, general notes).

Tips and tricks Part 1

- Know what has to be recorded.
- Think ahead.
- Listen for strange or unexpected noises
- Listen for crew noise.
- Keep clear detailed records. You can never give enough info to post.

Tips and tricks Part 2

- Record room tone.
- Record atmosphere.
- Record sfx that will be useful to post.

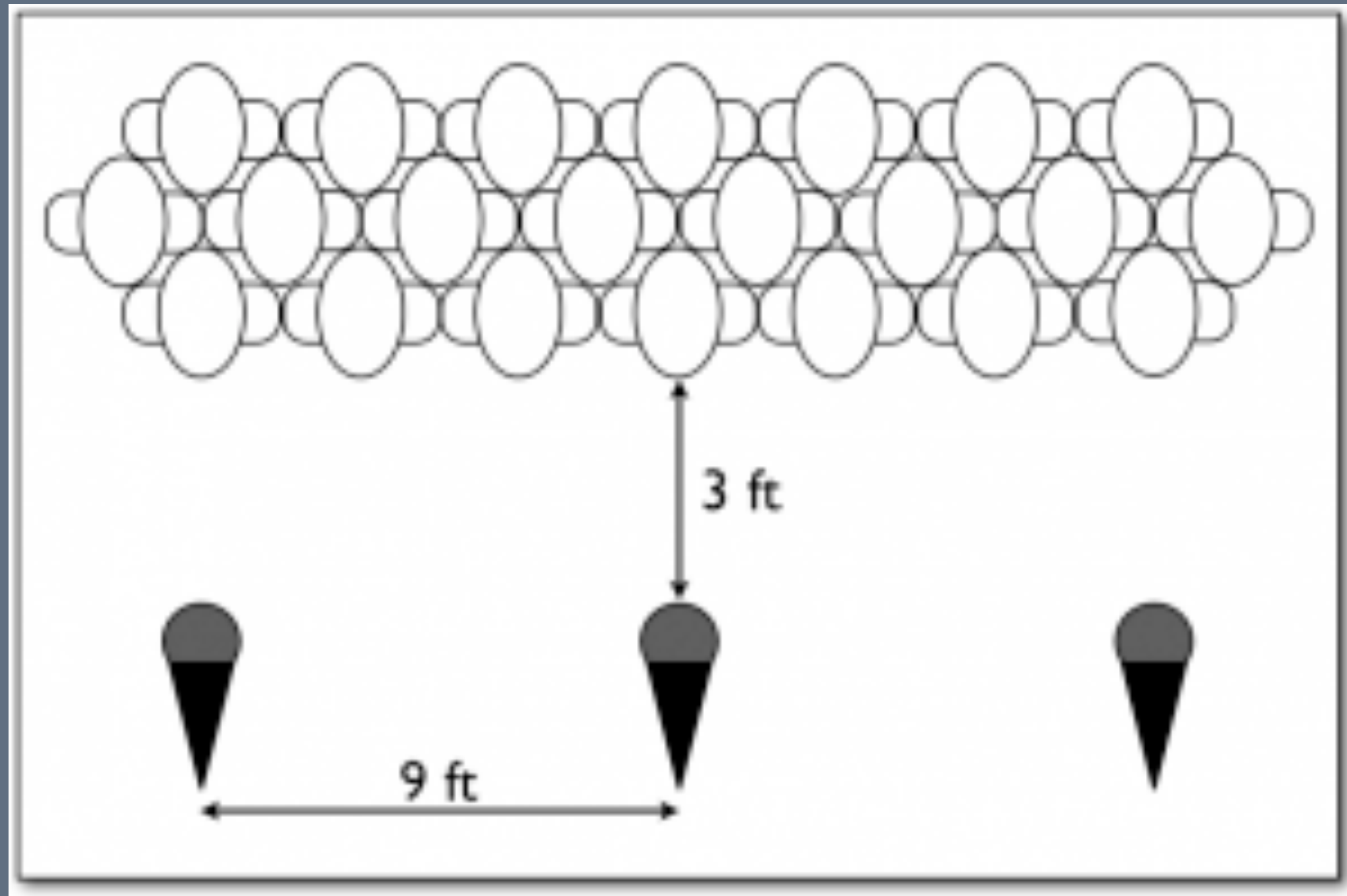
Tips and tricks Part 3

- Be friendly but don't bother people.
- Know where you are supposed to be.
- Never hurry. Panic results in mistakes.
- Set a backup channel with a limiter.

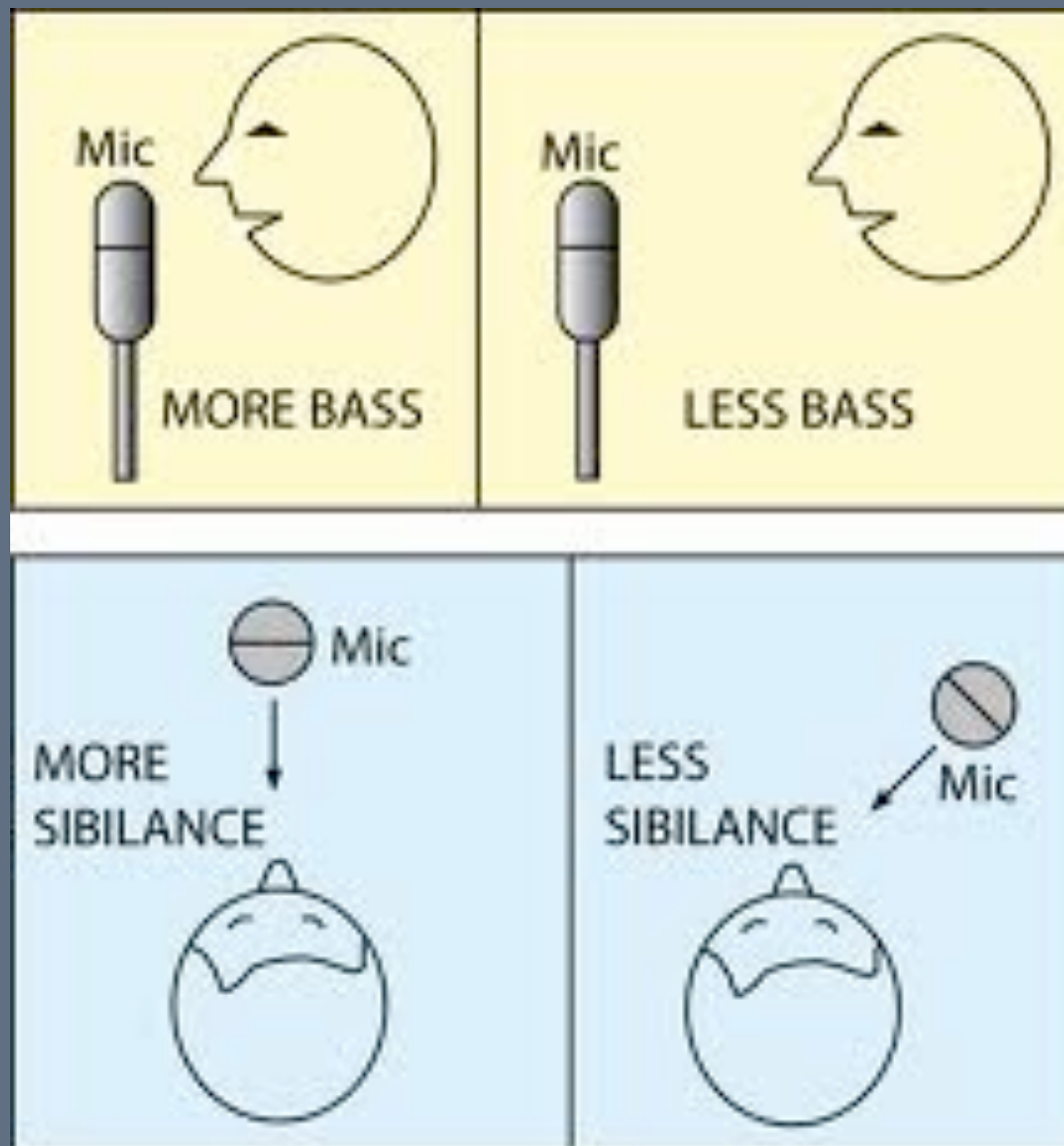
3:1 Rule of Mic Placement

- Good for ambience recordings
- When using 2 mics to record a source, place the 2nd mic three times the distance from the 1st mic as the 1st mic is from the source.
- If 1st mic is a foot from source, the 2nd mic should be placed 3 feet from the 1st mic.
- Minimizes phase problems created by delay.

3:1 Rule of Mic Placement



Mic Placement Images



Mic Placement Images



Mic Placement Images



Mic Placement Images





Do's

- Understand what you need to record and what's most important to capture that day.
- Have the right equipment in working order.
- Protect the equipment when moving it.
- Check the weather forecast.
- Make sure your formats are compatible with post.



Don't's

- Be a one person sound crew.
- Forget several windscreens of different efficacies.
- Record too hot or cold.
- Leave equipment lying around.
- Leave equipment out of the sound crew's sight.



Personal stuff

- Be comfortable, but be prepared for weather changes.
- Have appropriate comfortable shoes.
- Don't wear items that make noise.
- Have food/caffeine on hand in case of very long days.



Overview

- If you are using the right equipment correctly, the sound quality will be good.
- Know the location. Be set up and tested well before recording commences.